



AP PHOTO/AIJAZ RAHI

No Freedom from Politics

BANGALORE For doctor Mohammed Haneef, who flew home to freedom on July 29 after almost a month in detention in Australia once charges of terror activities against him were dropped, it was a homecoming he could have only dreamt of. Karnataka Chief Minister H.D. Kumaraswamy offered him a senior doctor's post in the state government run hospitals. The generous offer was apparently a bid to hide the embarrassment over

state Home Minister M.P. Prakash's remarks about Haneef's possible link to a terror network. Kumaraswamy's offer seems to be aimed at appeasing the numerically strong Muslim community in the state. "It is a humanitarian gesture and there is nothing political about it," says Kumaraswamy.

Haneef says he has "kept all the options open". But sources close to the family believe that he has been persuaded by his kin not to return to

DOC TALES: Haneef has got an offer to write a book

Australia nor bite Kumaraswamy's bait. Post-Australia, Haneef has decided to speak only through his lawyer Peter Russo, who flew in with the former Queensland-based doctor, a graduate from Bangalore's B.R. Ambedkar Medical College.

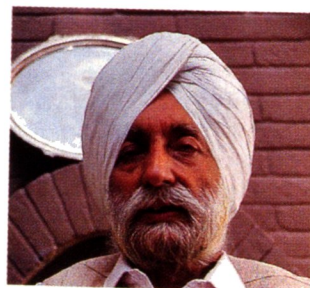
Ashfaq Ahmed, father of his wife Firdous, who handled the nearly 100-strong media contingent that camped at her parental bungalow, does not want him to return to Australia either. Dubai or a Middle East city is a serious option on the radar, according to family sources.

Haneef has also been approached for authoring a book about his experience. He says Haniya, his daughter who was born a week before he was detained in Australia, is a lot of good news and inspiration for him. Incidentally, Haniya in Arabic means 'pleased' or 'happy'.

by Stephen David

Final Justice

CHANDIGARH After 12 years, 400 witnesses, seven judges and in between an audacious jail-break, the trial for the assassination of former Punjab chief minister Beant Singh ended on July 31 with a special CBI court sentencing two of the six held guilty to death, three to life imprisonment and acquitting one.



Beant Singh

The court, held in the high-security Burail jail, handed out death sentence on dreaded Babbar Khalsa militant Jagtar Singh Hawara and Balwant Singh, a former Punjab Police cop who facilitated the human bomb to breach the security cover. Beant Singh, along with 17 others, was killed in the blast in the porch of Punjab Civil Secretariat in Chandigarh on August 31, 1995.

Expectedly, the slain Congress chief minister's family promptly hailed the verdict with a "justice at last" statement, but the death penalty to Hawara and Balwant has given radical Sikh organisations another rallying point. The Khalsa Action Committee has given a call for 'ardas divas' at the Akal Takht on August 4. Clearly, yet another round of convulsions in the Panthic politics is round the corner.

by Ramesh Vinayak

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